Rest in Peace?

with poems by Pages Matam and Amin 'Drew Law' Dallal and Harry Hogg

Vitiligo by Pages Matam and Amin 'Drew Law' Dallal

PAGES: **(Pgs 26-28)** *(imitating a heart monitor)* Beep.

Beep.

AMIN: *(chimes in, singing up tempo)* * Cuz it don't mean a thing / If you ain't got the go-go swing

SIMULTANEOUSLY

PAGES: *(keeping time in the background)* Beep. Beep.

Beep.

AMIN: *(singing)* Doo-wop, Doo-wop, Doo-wop, Doo-wop,

Doo-wooooooooop . . .

PAGES: Beeeeeep.

TOGETHER: *(as if using a defibrillator)* CLEAR!

INTRODUCTION

DC's Black population has been shrinking since the 1980s, after being the majority for over 50 years (from the late 1950s through 2011). Contributing factors include the rising cost of living, gentrification displacing residents

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from historically Black neighborhoods, and Black families moving to the suburbs seeking more affordable housing and better schools.

In their poem, "Vitiligo," Pages Matam and Amin 'Drew Law' Dallal convey a passion and deep sense of concern about their beloved city.

AMIN: 1790 -- Alexander Hamilton proposed that the capital of the United States be on federal land, in turn giving it no statehood.

PAGES: The pre-operative period.

TOGETHER: Welcome to America's purgatory!

PAGES: This city is an illusion. A magic trick gone awry.

TOGETHER: Tummy tucked behind a Capitol Hill.

AMIN: 1814 - The Redcoats set you on fire. The burning of Washington.

TOGETHER: First operation, and you've been addicted to the surgery ever since.

PAGES: With no anesthesia, they're trying to make monsters out of you.

AMIN: From The District to District Nine. As if you were ever ugly . . . The blemishes of your roads swept under cherry blossoms

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TOGETHER: You're nice to look at, but they're only here for your sight-seeing. D.C., you are a trophy wife.

AMIN: Minority-owned businesses, cut under the scalpels of high-rises

TOGETHER: Before U Street became THEIR Street

AMIN: Let 'em have a few Ethiopian restaurants here,

PAGES: A carry-out or two there,

TOGETHER: Cuz we all like that good ole Mambo sauce! *(sarcastic laughter)* Ha ha ha ha! But most times, this city has nothing to smile about.

AMIN: 1968 - Dr. King was assassinated. Race riots ensued for five days. The inner-city economy never crossed the finish line.

TOGETHER: Surgery number two. The addiction continued.

PAGES: A city so violent, they sought to go from Bullets to *(basketball shooting motion)* Wizards. Ironic how the same black magic still happens

TOGETHER: We are still disappearing, under a new form of violence. Same aim, different kind of "Target," but don't expect more. . .

PAGES: Face lift the streets and bleach all the borders.

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AMIN: **Chocolate City is melting.

TOGETHER: Liposuction via housing prices relative to income. You already can't vote***, what makes you think you're allowed to live here?

PAGES: This city has the gentry's vitiligo, spreading at the speed of a slow wildfire.

AMIN: Buying into a future blocked from the rest of us

TOGETHER: Why do you think it is called ***Wall*** -Mart? (as and ER crew with a *defibrillator*) We are losing the city! We are losing the city! Resuscitate . . . CLEAR!

PAGES: Nip / Tuck the schools. A segregated education, makes for a better segregated outcome!

TOGETHER: CLEAR!

AMIN: Taxation without representation.

TOGETHER: CLEAR!

PAGES: Replace whole bodies with Whole Foods

TOGETHER: CLEAR!

PAGES: We want our cities back.

AMIN: Oakland. Harlem.

PAGES: We want our cities back.

AMIN: Chicago. St. Louis.

PAGES: We want our cities back.

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AMIN: Portland. Philadelphia.

TOGETHER: I want my city back . . . CLEAR!

AMIN: How many lives will it cost to augment a metropolis?

PAGES: Our businesses do not need your Botox. Our culture does not need your collagen.

TOGETHER: Politicians and developers, playing surgeons reconstructing the go-go soul of our land. Gentrification by incision of jackhammers, turning the city into an illusion. . . A magic trick gone awry.

SIMULTANEOUSLY

AMIN: *(soft, slow, melancholy tempo)* * Cuz it don't mean a thing / If you ain't got that swing Doo-wop, Doo-wop, Doo-wop, Doo-wop, Doo-wooooooooop . . .

PAGES: D.C., you are magical. You are beautiful. But there will never be a recovery period for this surgery

TOGETHER: CLEAR!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Pages Matam and Amin 'Drew Law' Dallal
Book: Speaking Truths: Young Adults, Identity and Spoken Word Activism by Valerie Chepp, Pgs 26 - 28
ISBN: 978-1978801110
Publisher: Rutgers University Press
Date (Month/Year): Feb 2022

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[1] *Vitiligo is a condition in which the* pigment *is lost from areas of the skin, causing whitish patches, often with no clear cause.*

[2] ***Lyrics and Music*** *- Ella Fitzgerald and Duke Ellington's "It Don't Mean a Thing (If It Ain't Got That Swing)" can be found here* ***https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=myRc-3oF1d0***

[3] *Washington, D.C. earned the nickname "Chocolate City" primarily due to its large and influential African American population, which at one point constituted a majority. It reflected the city's vibrant Black culture and community. The nickname, while rooted in a specific time, continues to resonate with Washingtonians and serves as a reminder of the city's history and the significant contributions of its Black community.*

[4] *D.C.'s residents can vote in presidential elections, a right granted in 1960 with the adoption of the 23rd Amendment to the Constitution, but have no voting representation in a Congress, as it is not a state.*

TRANSITION

Washington D.C. and the Capitol building are often considered cornerstones of American democracy. So too are the elements that support and maintain a democratic society: fair elections, rule of law, public education and civic engagement. In our recent history, each of these fundamental principles has come under attack. Are live-saving measures enough for Washington DC and American democracy? Or is the concept of democracy dying a slow death with no means of survival? R.I.P Democracy by Harry Hogg

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R.I.P. Democracy by Harry Hogg

Finally, there's no one left, no echoes, no one to hear the falling down of rain. Nothing moves, turns, climbs, everything is caught standing still

It started with illegitimate lies told while the truth was kept behind bolted doors, no key could be found, so old lies were dusted off and retold

It was a lingering death, passing in silence, as night into day, while no one heard its last breath, it's anxieties unresolved, given up to blind trust

Damn those leaders who told us to expect that one day, things will change, go back to what we're told was normal. Where now are the guardians of truth?

There must be reasons for this unnoticed disappearance of a democracy, lost without passion, just a nation that was built on a sagging floor

The democratic experiment is now no more than a vision, a poltergeist, a ghost who walks the People's House after Congress and the Senate left

What we have done was done deliberately, starting with misplaced sensibilities in a president who took no pride in his words or his influence

Figures, once citizens of a brave new world now move behind barred windows, shadows passing drawn blinds, in the landscape of a dictatorship

Who knew the span of America's concentration? Short lived dreams, learning no new lessons, quick to battlefields, but not the one at home

Democracy was always a battle lost. While all our backs were turned, some new culture crept in, so evil, so powerful, that of an uncrowned king

What tore to shreds our moral bible, our societies desire to love? It came like a virus, vaccine resistant to 300 million battles against one to one

The harvester came and no wheat was there, no love ever fostered, only shells and tanks are rusting there, a lunar landscape barren, and bare

Children are starving, men are dying while we live complaining about the price of gas, inflation, while we, whole and safe, are not fleeing from home

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We only see each other at some distance, disappearing in the mist of disbelief, but it's happening before our eyes, a democracy just out of our grasp

R.I.P democracy, you weren't here long enough, we miss you, the dream that cannot be our children's dream, no distress signals ever, no sign of S.O.S.

REFRAIN FROM VITILIGO *(soft, slow, melancholy tempo)* *****

Cuz it don't mean a thing / If you ain't got that swing Doo-wop, Doo-wop, Doo-wop, Doo-wop, Doo-wooooooooop . . .

Beep. Beep. Beep. Beeeeeep. *(as if using a defibrillator)*

CLEAR!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Harry Hogg
On-Line Publication: Medium's Illumination
Weblink: https://medium.com/illumination/r-i-p-democracy-d4d7bd30915c
Publisher: Mediuim.com/illumination/
Date (Month/Year): July 13, 2022

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